

ENGINE 61

SCENARIO-BASED COMPARTMENT CHECK-OFF

An officer's call-and-response training guide — probationary firefighter edition

HOW TO RUN THIS

This isn't a written test. Sit the rookie down, or better yet, stand them in front of the rig with the compartment doors shut. Read “THE CALL” out loud like it's coming over the radio, nothing more. The rookie has to name every piece of equipment they'd grab, and — this is the part people skip — say which compartment it lives in. Don't accept “somewhere in the back”. If they can't point to the door, they don't know the rig yet, and that's the whole point of this drill.

Once they've named the gear, open “WHERE IT GOES WRONG” and walk through it together. This section is the mentoring, not the quiz. These are the mistakes that get made on these exact calls, told straight. Don't soften it — the rookie standing in front of you needs to hear it the way you'd want to hear it your first year.

Ten scenarios are covered: Lockout, Lift Assist, Cardiac Arrest, Structure Fire, CO Alarm, Fire Alarm Activation, Motor Vehicle Accident / Extrication, Gas Leak / Odor Investigation, Water / Ice Rescue, and Vehicle Fire. Every piece of equipment referenced is drawn directly from Engine 61's actual compartment inventory — this is Engine 61 only. Other rigs get their own version.

A rookie who can recite the gear list but can't tell you why the mistake matters hasn't learned anything yet. Make them explain the “why” in their own words before you move to the next scenario.

SCENARIO 1 LOCKOUT

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

“Engine 61, respond to 415 Elm St for a lockout. Caller advises a toddler is locked inside a vehicle in the driveway, engine off, unknown responsiveness.” (Officer's follow-up variant: a commercial lockout — panel company can't reach a keyholder.)

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
Window Punch	Rear Middle — Extrication Equipment
Flat Head Axe	Compartment 2 — Hand Tools & Forcible Entry
Halligan Bar	Compartment 2 — Hand Tools & Forcible Entry
Knoxbox Key	Inside Cab
K-Tool (in Leather Case)	Compartment 2 — Hand Tools & Forcible Entry
W-Tool	Compartment 5 — Officer Side Forcible Entry & Search

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- A window punch goes in the corner of tempered glass near the frame, not the center of a windshield — laminated glass will just flex and eat the strike.
- Don't rip a door off before you've actually confirmed it's locked and there's no keyholder five minutes out. Lockouts turn into “why is there a hole in this homeowner's door” fast.
- If there's any doubt about that kid's responsiveness or heat exposure, this stopped being a lockout the second you had that doubt. Force entry now, sort out the paperwork later.
- On a commercial box, try the Knox Box and the alarm company before the K-tool ever comes out. That tool leaves a mark — don't leave one you didn't need to.

SCENARIO 2

LIFT ASSIST

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

“Engine 61, respond to 220 Maple Ct for a lift assist. Elderly female, ground-level fall, family states she is not injured and just needs help up.”

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
Red Jump Bag — “First In”	Inside Cab
Blankets	Inside Cab
Gloves (universal precautions)	Personal PPE — worn, not stowed

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- This is a technique call, not a tool call, and the rookie mistake here is grabbing an armpit and hauling. Use a gait belt, lift with your legs, count it out loud — a probie who throws his back out on a routine lift assist in year one is a real, common story.
- “Not injured” from family is not a medical clearance. Every fall gets assessed — how long down, any head strike, what meds is she on. Skipping that because it “looks routine” is how you miss the bleed that kills someone two days later.
- Don't stand her up and walk out. Watch her walk. If something's off, that lift assist just became a refusal-of-transport conversation, and you'd better document it.

SCENARIO 3

CARDIAC ARREST

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

“Engine 61, respond to 88 Oakwood Dr for a cardiac arrest. 67-year-old male, unresponsive, not breathing normally, bystander CPR in progress.”

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
Red Jump Bag — “First In”	Inside Cab
AED (ZOLL)	Inside Cab
Green Airway Bag	Inside Cab
Small Orange Bag — Suction Unit	Inside Cab
Blankets / Red Biohazard Bags	Inside Cab

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- Don't walk in and pause compressions to “assess the scene” for two minutes. Grab the jump bag and AED on your way in — you assess while compressions keep going, not before they start.
- Pads go on bare, dry skin. Sweat, medication patches, chest hair — clear it fast, but clear it, or the AED won't get a clean read and won't shock when it needs to.
- The AED doing the exciting part doesn't mean the airway bag sits forgotten. Compressions and airway management are what keep this person alive between shocks.
- Somebody manages the family and the crowd, and somebody has that suction unit staged before it's needed — not after.

SCENARIO 4

STRUCTURE FIRE

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

“Engine 61, respond first-due to 501 Birchwood Ave for a structure fire. Smoke and flames visible from a two-story single-family dwelling, occupants unknown.”

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
Airpack (SCBA)	Compartment 1 — Engineer's Compartment
1¾" Crosslay — 200 ft, Fog Nozzle	Cabin Compartment & Hose Bed
5" Supply Hose	Cabin Compartment & Hose Bed
Halligan Bar + Flat Head Axe (irons)	Compartment 2 — Hand Tools & Forcible Entry
Ventilation Fan	Compartment 3 — Rescue, Ventilation & Air Bags
Ground Ladder — 24 ft / Extension Ladder — 14 ft	Above Compartments
Pike Poles — 6 ft & 8 ft	Above Compartments
4-Gas Monitor	Inside Cab
Accountability Name Board	Inside Cab
Portable Radios (×4)	Inside Cab

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- Don't chase the fire without a charged line. If you can't confirm water at the nozzle before you pass the front door, you are not making entry — full stop. That's the mistake that's killed firefighters.
- Your name tag goes on that board before you mask up, every single time. That board is how command knows you're still alive when things go bad inside.
- "Out" doesn't mean safe air. Run the 4-gas monitor before anybody pulls a mask off inside during overhaul — CO and low oxygen don't announce themselves.
- SCBA discipline: don't crack your mask because you're tired or it's hot. Compromised air or disorientation means you follow the hoseline out — you don't improvise.

SCENARIO 5

CO ALARM

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

"Engine 61, respond to 14 Sycamore Ln for a CO alarm activation. Residents report the alarm sounding, no one reporting symptoms at this time."

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
4-Gas Monitor (CO, O2, H2S, Combustible)	Inside Cab
HCN Sensor (Standalone)	Inside Cab
ERG — Emergency Response Guidebook	Inside Cab

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- Don't confuse the CO2 meter with your CO reading — two completely different gases, easy mix-up under stress. Know exactly which sensor is telling you what.
- Don't clear a house because "nobody feels sick." CO poisoning doesn't always announce itself with symptoms before it's dangerous. Trust the meter, not the residents' self-report.
- Walk the whole structure, not just the room with the detector. CO moves with the HVAC system — zero by the front door doesn't mean the basement by the furnace is clean.
- A real number turns this into an evacuation-and-ventilation call, not a reset-and-leave call. Don't let an impatient homeowner rush that decision.

SCENARIO 6

FIRE ALARM ACTIVATION

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

"Engine 61, respond to 900 Commerce Way, a commercial building, for a fire alarm activation. Panel shows a pull station on the third floor, no smoke reported by occupants."

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
Knoxbox Key	Inside Cab
Elevator Key	Inside Cab
4-Gas Monitor	Inside Cab
ERG — Emergency Response Guidebook	Inside Cab
Portable Radios (×4)	Inside Cab

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- The most dangerous habit on this call is treating it as “just another false alarm.” Most are — until the one that isn't. Walk every one like it's real.
- Don't take the panel's word or the occupant's word for it. Physically go to the indicated zone and confirm with your own eyes — and the gas monitor — before resetting anything.
- Elevators: know before you go whether you're recalling them or riding them. Riding toward an unconfirmed fire floor is a mistake taught in every academy for a reason.
- Resetting the panel and leaving without confirming cause with building management is how the same “nuisance alarm” turns into a real fire your crew gets sent back to at 3 a.m.

SCENARIO 7

MOTOR VEHICLE ACCIDENT — EXTRICATION

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

“Engine 61, respond to Rt 53 and Butterfield Rd for a two-vehicle accident with entrapment. Caller states one occupant is trapped and unresponsive.”

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
Hurst Rescue Cutter / Spreader	Rear Middle — Extrication Equipment
Hydraulic Ram	Rear Middle — Extrication Equipment
Reciprocating Saw	Rear Middle — Extrication Equipment
Window Punch	Rear Middle — Extrication Equipment
Hurst Batteries (×6)	Rear Middle — Extrication Equipment
Cribbing	Compartment 3 — Rescue, Ventilation & Air Bags
Backboards (×2)	Rear — Left Side & Backboards
Red Jump Bag / AED	Inside Cab
Traffic Cones	Top of Engine
ABC / Silver Bullet Extinguisher	Compartment 7 — Extinguishers & Special Hazards
Oil Dry	Compartment 7 — Extinguishers & Special Hazards

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- Stabilize before you touch it. A car on its side or roof is not a stable work platform — cribbing goes down first, every time, before a single tool touches that vehicle.
- Nobody puts a spreader or cutter on a vehicle without a charged line or extinguisher standing by. Cutting in blind with a fuel or battery hazard present is how a bad day gets worse.
- Know where the un-deployed airbags and the battery are before you start cutting. That's part of the size-up, not something you discover mid-cut.
- Everyone's focused on the patient, and that's exactly when scene safety gets skipped. Someone has to be watching the traffic lane, or your extrication crew becomes the next patient.

SCENARIO 8

GAS LEAK / ODOR OF GAS INVESTIGATION

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

"Engine 61, respond to 77 Willow St for an odor of gas inside a residence. Homeowner reports a strong smell near the kitchen."

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
4-Gas Monitor	Inside Cab
HCN Sensor	Inside Cab
Hot Stick	Inside Cab
Blue Lock-Out/Tag-Out Bag	Inside Cab
ERG — Emergency Response Guidebook	Inside Cab
Portable Radios (×4)	Inside Cab

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- No switches, no sparks. Don't flip a light switch, and don't key your own portable radio inside a confirmed gas atmosphere — key up outside, not standing in the kitchen with the meter screaming.
- Meter first, nose second. "I don't smell it that bad" is not a safety assessment — read the meter before you decide how far into that structure you're willing to go.
- Ventilate smart, not fast. Throwing every window open blind can create a flow path you haven't thought through if there's an ignition source anywhere in the structure.
- Know when it's above your pay grade. A confirmed high reading means gas company and possibly evacuation — not "let's air it out and get back in service."

SCENARIO 9

WATER / ICE RESCUE

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

“Engine 61, respond to the retention pond behind 300 Lakeview Dr. Caller reports a person through the ice, visible and conscious, approximately 40 feet from shore.”

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
Mustang Suit	Compartment 6 — Middle Officer / Water Rescue
Ice Spikes & Ice Cleats	Compartment 6 — Middle Officer / Water Rescue
Rope Throw Bag	Compartment 6 — Middle Officer / Water Rescue
Life Safety Ring	Compartment 6 — Middle Officer / Water Rescue
Strap with 3 Carabiners	Compartment 6 — Middle Officer / Water Rescue
Water Helmet	Compartment 6 — Middle Officer / Water Rescue
Air Bottles (×4)	Compartment 6 — Middle Officer / Water Rescue
Red Bag — 4 PFDs & Throw Preserver	Compartment 5 — Officer Side Forcible Entry & Search
Utility Rope — 100 ft	Compartment 5 — Officer Side Forcible Entry & Search

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- Reach, throw, row, go — in that order. Going onto the ice or into the water is not your first move. The Mustang suit and a rope are there so a trained rescuer goes in tethered, not so anybody freelances across the ice.
- Nobody without a PFD gets within reach of that shoreline. Bystanders wander toward the edge to “help” and become the second victim — one of the most common ways these calls turn worse.
- Check the gear before you need it, not during. A tangled rope bag or a Mustang suit with a broken zipper does not get discovered for the first time mid-rescue.
- Ice is never “safe enough” just because someone's already standing on it. Thickness varies across the same pond — that's exactly why this is a tethered, team evolution, not a solo dash.

SCENARIO 10

VEHICLE FIRE

THE CALL — WHAT THE OFFICER READS ALOUD

“Engine 61, respond to I-355 southbound for a vehicle fire. Caller states smoke and flames from the engine compartment, occupants out and clear.”

WHAT YOU NEED

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
1¾" Crosslay, Fog Nozzle	Cabin Compartment & Hose Bed
ABC Dry Chemical Extinguisher	Compartment 7 — Extinguishers & Special Hazards

EQUIPMENT	COMPARTMENT / LOCATION
Silver Bullet — Pressurized Water	Compartment 7 — Extinguishers & Special Hazards
CO2 Extinguisher	Compartment 7 — Extinguishers & Special Hazards
Fire Blanket — Electric Vehicle	Compartment 7 — Extinguishers & Special Hazards
Oil Dry	Compartment 7 — Extinguishers & Special Hazards
Halligan Bar (stuck hood latch)	Compartment 2 — Hand Tools & Forcible Entry
Traffic Cones	Top of Engine

WHERE IT GOES WRONG — LISTEN UP

- Approach from the side at an angle, not head-on — bumpers and structural components under load can fail and strike you, and you don't know yet what's pressurized under that hood.
- Don't pop the hood wide open like a stovetop grease fire. Crack it a few inches, hit what you can see, then open the rest once it's knocked down.
- Electric vehicle fires are not a “wet stuff on the red stuff, go home” call. If there's any chance it's an EV, that changes your agent, your water usage, and your overhaul — battery fires can reignite hours later. Know the difference before you're standing in front of one.
- It's still a highway. Traffic cones and upstream blocking apparatus go out before anyone charges a line two feet off a live travel lane.